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Emotional Clarity and Responses to Peer Victimization as Predictors of Youth Aggression

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During the transition to middle school, difficulties understanding and identifying emotions may place youth at risk for maladaptive responses to peer victimization. In turn, maladaptive responses to victimization may increase the likelihood of engaging in aggressive behaviors. In a prospective, multi-informant study of 636 youth (338 girls; M_{age} in fourth grade = 9.94 years; 66.7% White; 34.75% receiving subsidized lunch) from fourth to sixth grades (2008–2011), we examined the indirect pathways from emotional clarity to aggressive behavior via responses to peer victimization. Results revealed that poor emotional clarity predicted less effortful engagement and more involuntary disengagement responses to peer victimization, which predicted more aggressive behaviors. These results highlight the importance of promoting emotional understanding to enhance effective coping with victimization and reduce aggression.

Keywords: emotional clarity, responses to victimization, aggression

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The transition from elementary to middle school can be a tumultuous developmental period. During this transition, youth encounter a novel social environment along with a reorganization of peer group structure (Fite et al., 2019; Lovette-Wilson et al., 2022). These changes can precipitate multiple peer-related challenges and stressors, including exposure to peer victimization, which can increase the likelihood of youth engaging in aggressive behavior (Cooley & Fite, 2016; Lamarche et al., 2007; Ostrov et al., 2014). According to theories of affective social competence, the subjective experience of emotions contributes to how youth manage complex, dynamic social interactions (Camras & Halberstadt, 2017; Halberstadt et al., 2001) and may, therefore, play a critical role in how youth respond to the growing social challenges during middle school.

One critical aspect of affective social competence is emotional clarity—conceptualized as the ability to identify, understand, and distinguish one's own emotional states (Boden et al., 2013; Gohm & Clore, 2000, 2002; Saarni, 2007; Salovey et al., 1995). Emotional clarity is a critical component of emotion-related skills such as theory of mind and emotional intelligence and is related to adjustment in later development (Gohm & Clore, 2000, 2002; for a review, see Saarni, 2007; Thompson et al., 2015). Past research has shown that youths' ability to identify and understand their emotions may predict the likelihood that they engage in adaptive or maladaptive responses when faced with peer victimization (Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014). The goal of this research was to explore whether compromised emotional clarity undermines youths' responses to peer victimization, which in turn contributes to engagement in higher levels of aggression during the transition to middle school.

Responses to Peer Victimization as a Predictor of Youth Aggressive Behavior

When exposed to peer victimization, youth might engage in adaptive responses (i.e., those that lead to positive long-term outcomes; Kochenderfer-Ladd, 2004; Visconti & Troop-Gordon, 2010) or maladaptive responses (i.e., those that lead to negative long-term outcomes; Abaied & Rudolph, 2011; Kochenderfer-Ladd, 2004; Rudolph et al., 2011). Contemporary conceptualizations of responses to victimization distinguish among four categories: effortful engagement (efforts to modify or adapt to stressors; e.g., cognitive restructuring, emotion regulation, problem solving), effortful disengagement (efforts directed away from stressors; e.g., avoidance, denial, wishful thinking), involuntary engagement (automatic responses directed toward stressors; e.g., rumination, impulsive action, emotional arousal), and involuntary disengagement (automatic responses directed away from stressors; e.g., emotional numbing, escape, inaction; Brewer & Santiago, 2018; Compas et al., 1997, 2001; Rudolph et al., 2021; Wolff et al., 2009). Broadly, effortful

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engagement responses are conceptualized as adaptive, whereas effortful disengagement and involuntary responses are conceptualized as maladaptive (Compas et al., 2001; Monti & Rudolph, 2017).

If youth engage in a purposeful way when facing peer victimization—such as making efforts to regulate their emotions, solve problems, or reappraise the situation—they may be better able to resolve stressors and to decrease negative affective or cognitive states (Monti & Rudolph, 2017), thereby decreasing their likelihood of responding with aggressive behavior (Connor-Smith et al., 2000; Cumming et al., 2019; Rudolph et al., 2011; Wolff et al., 2009). On the other hand, if youth engage in excessive rumination or deny the situation when facing peer victimization, they may fail to resolve stressors or consider the consequences of their actions, potentially exacerbating negative affective states (e.g., anger) and promoting aggressive behavior (Connor-Smith et al., 2000; Cumming et al., 2019; Del Giudice et al., 2011; Langrock et al., 2002; Moroń & Biolik-Moroń, 2021; Susman, 2006; Vreeland et al., 2019). Indeed, past research has found that youth who show more maladaptive responses to interpersonal stress and peer victimization are more likely to engage in aggressive behaviors (Hampel & Petermann, 2006; Herts et al., 2012). Thus, we hypothesized that effortful disengagement and involuntary responses to peer victimization would predict more aggressive behaviors, whereas effortful engagement responses to peer victimization would predict fewer aggressive behaviors.

Emotional Clarity as a Predictor of Responses to Peer Victimization

Given the impact of responses to victimization on youths' likelihood of engaging in aggressive behavior, it is critical to identify individual differences that determine variations in how they respond when they are victimized by peers. Consistent with the affective social competence model, which suggests that the ability to identify and understand one's emotional states can serve as a precursor to behaviors within a social context (Camras & Halberstadt, 2017; Gohm & Clore, 2000, 2002; Halberstadt et al., 2001; Saarni, 2007), the present research explored the possibility that emotional clarity, one component of affective social competence, contributes to youths' responses to victimization. Broadly, individuals who are better at identifying and understanding their emotional states are at lower risk for social problems, depression, and externalizing behaviors when compared to those who have difficulties identifying and understanding their emotions (Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014; Hamilton et al., 2016; Moroń & Biolik-Moroń, 2021; Rudolph et al., 2020; Thompson et al., 2015).

Youth with higher levels of emotional clarity may require fewer attentional resources to identify their emotional states and, therefore, may have more resources available for engaging in cognitively costly, effortful coping in response to victimization, such as cognitive restructuring, emotion regulation, or problem solving (Boden et al., 2012; Boden & Thompson, 2015; Garofalo et al., 2016; Gohm & Clore, 2000, 2002; Ma & Fang, 2019; Moroń & Biolik-Moroń, 2021). In contrast, youth who lack emotional clarity may require more attentional resources to identify their emotional states, leaving less energy for youth to engage in adaptive responses to victimization. Thus, these youth may be more likely to purposely avoid stressors or respond to stressors in an involuntary manner that uses fewer attentional resources. Poor emotional clarity may therefore interfere with effective social information processing during peer encounters, potentially leading to inaccurate appraisals of social cues, heightened emotional arousal, and consequent involuntary, dysregulated behaviors when victimized (Burt & Donnellan, 2008; Ciairano et al., 2007; Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014; Garofalo et al., 2021; Mathews et al., 2014; Moustafa et al., 2017; Van Goozen et al., 2007). Indeed, past research reveals that youth with higher emotional clarity show more adaptive responses to peer victimization, such as effortful engagement, whereas youth with lower emotional clarity show more maladaptive, involuntary responses to peer victimization (Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014).

Reciprocal Effects of Responses to Peer Victimization on the Development of Emotional Clarity

Although there is evidence to support the notion that emotional clarity fosters the development of adaptive responses to victimization, it may also be true that the way a youth responds to victimization contributes to the development of emotional clarity. However, these pathways have yet to be explored in past empirical research. Youth who more frequently use effortful engagement (e.g., regulating their emotions, seeking social support from friends or family) when encountering peer stressors likely spend more time and energy consciously reflecting on and coping with stressors. By actively approaching stressors, these youth may process their associated emotions more frequently and comprehensively, thereby increasing their ability to identify and distinguish their emotions. In contrast, youth who are overwhelmed by peer stressors may engage in involuntary actions (e.g., ruminating, expressing anger), which may interfere with emotional understanding. Similarly, youth who avoid or deny peer stressors through disengagement responses to victimization might have fewer opportunities to practice processing their emotions, making them less able to sharpen their skills at deciphering their emotions. Thus, we hypothesized that effortful disengagement and involuntary responses to peer victimization would predict lower emotional clarity, whereas effortful engagement responses to peer victimization would predict more emotional clarity.

Study Overview

The transition to middle school is characterized by increases in social stressors (Nelemans et al., 2018), which can place youth at risk for engaging in maladaptive behaviors such as aggression (Gazelle & Faldowski, 2019; Hampel & Petermann, 2006; Herts et al., 2012; Theriot & Dupper, 2010). Therefore, identifying individual differences that contribute to different patterns of responses to peer victimization is a critical step toward decreasing aggressive behaviors during this transition. Because separate lines of theory and research suggest that (a) youth with compromised emotional clarity are at higher risk for maladaptive responses to victimization and (b) youth who show maladaptive responses to victimization are more likely to engage in aggressive behaviors, we hypothesized that emotional clarity would indirectly contribute to aggression via responses to victimization. We focused, in particular, on responses to peer victimization given the salience of peer relationships during this developmental period and the impact of how youth cope with these stressors on their developmental trajectories (Erath et al., 2019; McLaughlin et al., 2009). Specifically, we hypothesized that (a) lower emotional clarity would predict less

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adaptive (i.e., effortful engagement) and more maladaptive (i.e., effortful disengagement, involuntary engagement, and involuntary disengagement) responses to victimization, which would predict more aggressive behavior, and (b) less adaptive and more maladaptive responses to victimization would predict lower emotional clarity. Furthermore, we aimed to explore whether the pathways leading toward aggression may differ between boys and girls.

Method

Participants

The present analyses used data from a larger longitudinal study (Rudolph et al., 2014) that was designed to understand the consequences of peer victimization for children's emotional, behavioral, and physiological development. Participants were 636 children (338 girls, 298 boys; 66.67% White, 21.70% African American, 7.08% Asian, .94% American Indian/Native Alaskan, .16% Mexican/Hispanic, and 3.46% multiracial; and 34.75% of participants received subsidized lunch; *M* age at the fourth grade assessment = 9.94, *SD* = 0.35) who were participating in a multiwave study across elementary and middle school from 2006 to 2014 (e.g., Rudolph et al., 2014). A priori power analyses for the larger longitudinal study revealed that a sample of 400 was needed to detect a moderate effect size. To account for potential lack of consent and attrition over the multiyear observation period, all eligible children at participating schools were invited to participate. Of the 725 eligible children in the second grade, 576 (80%) received parental consent. Nonparticipants at Wave 1 did not significantly differ from participants in sex, $\chi^2(1) = p = .15$, nonsignificant (ns); race (White vs. minority), $\chi^2(1) = .59$, p = ns; age, $t(723) = .63$, p = ns; or school lunch status (full pay vs. subsidized), $\chi^2(1) = .35$, p = ns. In the third grade, 60 classmates of the participating children were added, yielding a total of 636 participants. For the present analyses, we used data collected in the fourth, fifth, and sixth grade assessments that occurred between 2008 and 2011.

Procedure

Trained research assistants administered surveys during two classroom visits to small groups (three to four students) in elementary school (fourth and fifth grades) and large groups (15–20 students) in middle school (sixth grade). Teachers completed surveys and returned them to a lockbox at their school, in person, or by mail. Youth reported on emotional clarity in fourth and fifth grades; youth reported on responses to victimization, and teachers reported on youth aggression in fourth, fifth, and sixth grades. All study protocols were approved by the institutional review board, and all students included in the analyses had both written parental consent and oral self-assent.

Measures

Table 1 provides descriptive statistics and internal consistency of variables of interest for boys and girls. All measures have high internal consistency.

Emotional Clarity

To assess emotional clarity, youth completed the Emotional Clarity Questionnaire adapted from the Salovey et al. (1995) Trait

Table 1
Descriptive Data

Study variable	*M* (*SD*) Overall	Girl	Boy	*t*	95% CI [*LL*, *UL*]	*d*	α
Emotional clarity							
Fourth grade emotional clarity	3.57 (0.89)	3.54 (0.85)	3.61 (0.93)	.87	[−.082, .211]	.07	.89
Fifth grade emotional clarity	3.80 (0.90)	3.76 (0.94)	3.87 (0.86)	1.43	[−.041, .260]	.12	.92
Effortful engagement							
Fourth grade effortful engagement	0.39 (0.06)	0.40 (0.06)	0.39 (0.06)	−1.82†	[−.019, .001]	−.15	.86
Fifth grade effortful engagement	0.40 (0.06)	0.40 (0.07)	0.39 (0.06)	−1.34	[−.018, .003]	−.11	.86
Sixth grade effortful engagement	0.41 (0.07)	0.41 (0.07)	0.40 (0.06)	−1.21	[−.019, .004]	−.11	.87
Effortful disengagement							
Fourth grade effortful disengagement	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.03)	0.22 (0.04)	−.03	[−.006, .006]	−.00	.79
Fifth grade effortful disengagement	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.03)	0.22 (0.04)	−1.44	[−.010, .002]	−.12	.77
Sixth grade effortful disengagement	0.22 (0.03)	0.22 (0.03)	0.22 (0.04)	−0.63	[−.007, .004]	−.06	.80
Involuntary engagement							
Fourth grade involuntary engagement	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.04)	1.15	[−.003, .010]	.10	.82
Fifth grade involuntary engagement	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.04)	1.06	[−.003, .010]	.09	.83
Sixth grade involuntary engagement	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.04)	0.22 (0.04)	.90	[−.001, .010]	.08	.86
Involuntary disengagement							
Fourth grade involuntary disengagement	0.16 (0.03)	0.16 (0.03)	0.17 (0.03)	1.88†	[−.000, .011]	.16	.81
Fifth grade involuntary disengagement	0.16 (0.04)	0.16 (0.04)	0.17 (0.04)	2.09*	[−.000, .013]	.18	.82
Sixth grade involuntary disengagement	0.16 (0.03)	0.15 (0.04)	0.16 (0.03)	1.75†	[−.001, .011]	.15	.86
Aggression							
Fourth grade aggression	1.77 (0.79)	1.69 (0.74)	1.86 (0.84)	2.53*	[.037, .297]	.21	.61
Fifth grade aggression	1.74 (0.79)	1.74 (0.82)	1.73 (0.76)	−.11	[−.138, .123]	−.01	.72
Sixth grade aggression	1.54 (0.69)	1.49 (0.70)	1.59 (0.67)	1.61	[−.021, .211]	.14	.75

Note. CI = confidence interval; *LL* = lower limit; *UL* = upper limit.
† $p < .10$. * $p < .05$.

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Meta-Mood Scale (for information regarding adaptation, see Flynn & Rudolph, 2010). For each of the 10 items, youth rated on a 5-point scale (1 = *not at all* to 5 = *very much*) how well they could identify and understand their emotions (e.g., "I usually know exactly how I feel," "I often have a hard time understanding how I feel"). Negatively valenced items were reverse-scored, and a mean score was computed, with higher scores reflecting greater emotional clarity. The adapted Emotional Clarity Questionnaire has established internal consistency as well as discriminant and convergent validity (Flynn & Rudolph, 2010).

Responses to Victimization

To assess responses to victimization, youth completed a revised version (Abaied & Rudolph, 2011; Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014) of the Responses to Stress Questionnaire (Connor-Smith et al., 2000). For each of 41 items, youth rated on a 4-point scale (1 = *not at all* to 4 = *very much*) how they responded when experiencing peer victimization ("when other kids are mean"). The revised Responses to Stress Questionnaire includes 19 subscales that are used to create four broader subscales: Effortful Engagement (14 items reflecting Problem Solving, Emotion Regulation, Emotional Expression, Positive Thinking, Cognitive Restructuring, Distraction, and Acceptance subscales; e.g., "I do something to calm myself down," "I let someone know how I feel"), Effortful Disengagement (nine items reflecting Avoidance, Denial, and Wishful Thinking; e.g., "I say to myself 'this isn't real,'" "I try to stay away from people and things that make me feel upset or remind me of the problem"), Involuntary Engagement (10 items reflecting Rumination, Intrusive Thoughts, Physiological Arousal, Emotional Arousal, and Involuntary Action subscales; e.g., "I keep remembering what happened or can't stop thinking about what might happen," "I keep thinking about the problem when I try to sleep, or I have bad dreams about it"), and Involuntary Disengagement (eight items reflecting Emotional Numbing, Cognitive Interference, Inaction, and Escape; e.g., "I don't feel anything at all, it's like I have no feelings," "I just have to get away, I can't stop myself"). Proportion scores for each subscale were calculated by dividing the score for each individual subscale by the total score on the measure. The original and adapted measures have good internal consistency and test–retest reliability (Connor-Smith et al., 2000; Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014; Rudolph et al., 2011).

Aggression

To assess aggressive behavior, teachers completed the Children's Social Behavior Scale (Crick, 1996). For each of nine items, teachers rated on a 5-point scale (1 = *never true* to 5 = *almost always true*) how much youth engaged in behaviors reflecting overt aggression (four items; e.g., "this child hits or kicks peers") and relational aggression (five items; e.g., "when this child is mad at a peer, s/he gets even by excluding the peer from his or her clique or play group"). Scores for each subscale were computed by averaging across items within each subscale. Given the strong correlations between overt and relational aggression (rs = 0.44–0.60, ps < .001), overall aggression scores were computed by averaging across the two subscales. This measure has strong internal consistency and has been found to have high discriminant, convergent, and construct validity (Brandes et al., 2021; Cappella & Weinstein, 2006; Crick, 1996).

Analytic Plan

Prior to testing the hypothesized models, IBM SPSS Statistics (Version 28) predictive analytics software was used to conduct preliminary analyses examining patterns of missing data, mean differences between girls and boys, and intercorrelations among the variables. To examine the influence of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth grade aggression via fifth grade responses to victimization, a series of path analyses was conducted using MPlus Version 8.8 statistical software (Muthén & Muthén, 2017). Given our interest in distinguishing pathways associated with different types of responses to victimization, separate models were tested for each type of response (effortful engagement, effortful disengagement, involuntary engagement, and involuntary disengagement). Based on recommendations by Cole and Maxwell (2003), each model included emotional clarity in fourth and fifth grades and responses to victimization and aggression in fourth, fifth, and sixth grades. Cross-lagged paths were included from fourth and fifth grade emotional clarity and responses to victimization to fifth and sixth grade responses to victimization and emotional clarity, respectively. A directional path also was included from fourth and fifth grade responses to victimization to fifth and sixth grade aggression. Because a measure of sixth grade emotional clarity was not included in the study, the models included a unidirectional pathway from fifth grade emotional clarity to sixth grade responses to victimization. The models also included autoregressive paths and within-wave covariances between study variables. The indirect effects from fourth grade emotional clarity to sixth grade aggression via fifth grade responses to victimization were estimated using the MODEL INDIRECT command in MPlus and bootstrapping with 1,000 iterations. Child age at baseline, a variable that was available for all participants, was included as a predictor of sixth grade aggression and was correlated with all variables in fourth grade to allow us to estimate missing data and use the full sample of 636 children.

Multigroup comparison analyses and chi-square difference tests were used to examine sex differences in the paths by comparing fully constrained and fully unconstrained models (with the exception of the covariate, age, for which paths were constrained to be equal). For models with significant sex differences, structural paths and covariances for variables of interest were freely estimated for boys and girls. For models with no significant sex differences, all paths were constrained to be equal for boys and girls.

Finally, there is evidence that peer victimization is associated with both responses to stress (Gardner et al., 2017; Kochenderfer-Ladd, 2004; McWood et al., 2023; Troop-Gordon et al., 2017; Visconti & Troop-Gordon, 2010) and aggression (Cooley & Fite, 2016; Lamarche et al., 2007; Leadbeater & Hoglund, 2009; Ostrov, 2010). Therefore, we conducted a series of post hoc sensitivity analyses to examine the impact of including victimization in the model as either a moderator or a covariate. There was no evidence for moderation by peer victimization. Of the 20 unique pathways leading to responses to victimization and aggression across the final models (four pathways for the effortful engagement/disengagement and involuntary engagement models where paths were constrained to be the same for boys and girls; eight pathways for the involuntary disengagement model where paths were allowed to vary for boys and

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girls), victimization served as a predictor in only seven instances. Of those seven instances, including victimization as a covariate altered the significance of only two pathways, such that one significant pathway became marginal and one became nonsignificant.

Transparency and Openness

Our study follows Journal Article Reporting Standards (Appelbaum et al., 2018). We report how we determined our sample size and all measures included in the present analyses. There were no data exclusions. Data were analyzed using IBM SPSS Statistics Version 28 and MPlus Version 8.8 (Muthén & Muthén, 2017). This study's design and these analyses were not preregistered. All data, analysis code, and research materials are available at https://osf.io/6qpzs/?view_only=9e1deada52f94ed3b37bf8a1f34f8b63.

Results

Preliminary Analyses

Of the 636 participants, 555 (87.3%), 552 (86.8%), and 522 (82.1%) had complete data on all the variables in the present analyses in fourth, fifth, and sixth grades, respectively. Participants with complete data on these variables did not differ from those with missing data in sex, $\chi^2(1) = 1.36$, $p = .24$; ethnicity, $\chi^2(5) = 3.25$, $p = .65$; or school lunch status, $\chi^2(1) = .18$, $p = .67$. However, participants who had some missing data were significantly older at the first wave of the study than youth who did not have any missing data, $t(634) = -3.07$, $p = .01$. Little's missing completely at random test indicated that data were missing at random, $\Delta\chi^2(677) = 700.26$, $p = .26$; therefore, maximum likelihood estimation was used on all available data from 636 children when conducting path analyses.

Descriptive Statistics and Intercorrelations of Study Variables

Table 1 includes descriptive data for the study variables for the whole sample as well as for boys and girls separately and the reliability of the variables. Independent-samples *t* tests indicated that there were no significant differences between boys and girls on measures of emotional clarity, effortful disengagement, or involuntary engagement. Girls had marginally more fourth grade effortful engagement; boys had significantly more fifth grade involuntary disengagement and fourth grade aggression and marginally more fourth and fifth grade involuntary disengagement.

Table 2 includes intercorrelations among the variables. Emotional clarity was positively associated with effortful engagement but negatively associated with involuntary engagement and disengagement. Effortful engagement was negatively associated with aggression. Involuntary engagement and involuntary disengagement were positively associated with aggression.

Path Analyses Estimating Indirect Effect of Emotional Clarity on Aggressive Behavior via Responses to Peer Victimization

Figures 1–4 present unstandardized parameter estimates for the final models. To facilitate the readability of the figures, wave covariances and the predictive path from age to sixth grade aggression are

Table 2
Intercorrelations of Study Variables

Study variable	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17
1. Fourth grade EC	—	.42***	.42***	.39***	.26***	.03	−.04	−.11	−.30***	−.27***	−.17**	−.40***	−.34***	−.20**	−.02	−.03	−.07
2. Fifth grade EC	.40***	—	.29***	.41***	.40***	.01	−.04	−.11†	−.16*	−.24***	−.26***	−.34***	−.40***	−.37***	.02	−.09	−.03
3. Fourth grade EE	.46***	.28***	—	.54***	.44***	−.16**	−.02	−.10	.73***	−.41***	−.34***	−.76***	−.43***	−.35***	−.27***	−.22***	−.22***
4. Fifth grade EE	.35***	.50***	.59***	—	.58***	−.07	−.20**	−.18**	−.34***	−.71***	−.42***	−.49***	−.76***	−.46***	−.28***	−.23***	−.23***
5. Sixth grade EE	.27***	.41***	.48***	.65***	—	−.03	−.02	−.22***	−.26***	−.48***	−.80***	−.45***	−.42***	−.79***	−.16*	−.12†	−.22***
6. Fourth grade ED	.04	.13*	−.13*	.03	.01	—	.22***	.22***	−.32***	−.12†	−.11†	−.10	.09	.04	.01	.07	.02
7. Fifth grade ED	.08	.13*	−.04	−.06	.08	.36***	—	.27***	−.07	−.26***	−.16*	−.04	−.06	.05	−.01	.04	−.08
8. Sixth grade ED	−.01	−.07	−.02	−.08	−.20***	.24***	.39***	—	−.07	−.01	−.22***	.09	.13†	−.02	−.02	.16*	−.01
9. Fourth grade IE	−.31***	−.21***	−.79***	−.46***	−.41***	−.28***	−.13*	−.12*	—	.40***	.29***	.34***	.19**	.19**	.17***	.08	.12†
10. Fifth grade IE	−.28***	−.39***	−.51***	−.82***	−.57***	−.16**	−.27***	−.07	.54***	—	.49***	.34***	.28***	.32***	.25***	.18**	.20**
11. Sixth grade IE	−.22***	−.32***	−.43***	−.55***	−.87***	−.04	−.16**	−.11	.44***	.58***	—	.34***	.27***	.41***	.13*	.02	.21**
12. Fourth grade ID	−.50***	−.34***	−.76***	−.53***	−.35***	−.16**	−.02	.00	.40***	.38***	.26***	—	.47***	.37***	.25***	.23***	.23***
13. Fifth grade ID	−.37***	−.53***	−.45***	−.81***	−.56***	−.11†	−.23***	−.04	.30***	.51***	.43***	.53***	—	.38***	.21***	.17**	.22***
14. Sixth grade ID	−.28***	−.39***	−.43***	−.58***	−.83***	−.11†	−.20***	−.09	.37***	.48***	.60***	.39***	.62***	—	.16*	.09	.16*
15. Fourth grade agg	−.07	−.15**	−.21***	−.23***	−.18**	−.03	−.05	−.10†	.15**	.21***	.18**	.22***	.20***	.22**	—	.54***	.41***
16. Fifth grade agg	−.05	−.07	−.19**	−.25***	−.22***	.08	−.04	−.12*	.14*	.18**	.21***	.12*	.26***	.26***	.42***	—	.34***
17. Sixth grade agg	−.06	−.17**	−.106†	−.13*	−.23***	.00	−.03	−.07	.09	.20**	.25***	.08	.16**	.19**	.34***	.43***	—

Note. Values above the diagonal are for boys; values below the diagonal are for girls. EC = emotional clarity; EE = effortful engagement; ED = effortful disengagement; IE = involuntary engagement; ID = involuntary disengagement; agg = aggression.
$^{\dagger}p < .10$. $^{*}p < .05$. $^{**}p < .01$. $^{***}p < .001$.

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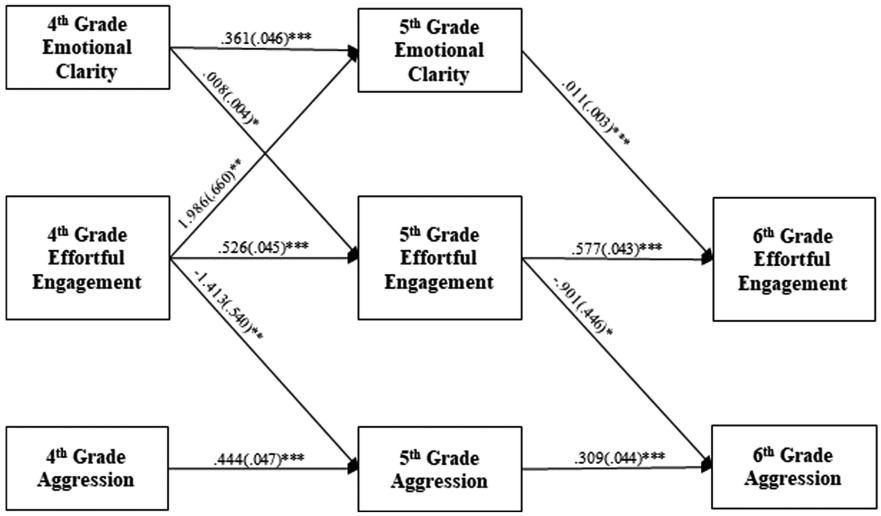
Figure 1
Indirect Effect of Emotional Clarity on Aggression via Effortful Engagement Responses to Victimization



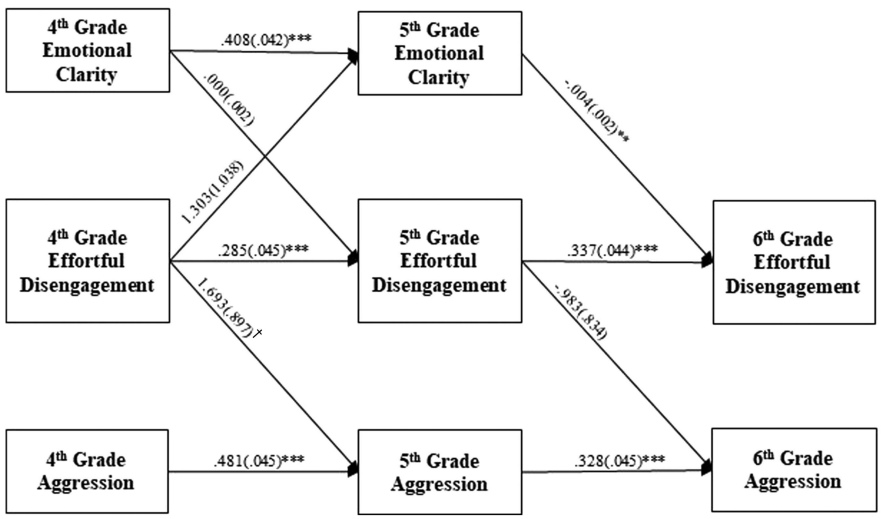
Note. Not shown are within-wave covariances or the predictive path for age.
$^{*}p < .05$. $^{**}p < .01$. $^{***}p < .001$.

not displayed. There were no sex differences for the effortful engagement, $\Delta\chi^2(17) = 25.32$, $p = .08$; effortful disengagement, $\Delta\chi^2(17) = 17.88$, $p = .40$; or involuntary engagement, $\Delta\chi^2(17) = 21.32$, $p = .21$, models. There were significant sex differences in the involuntary disengagement model, $\Delta\chi^2(17) = 35.70$, $p = .01$. Age did not significantly predict aggression in any of the four models. Comprehensive tables that include all fit statistics, coefficients, and confidence intervals are provided in the Supplemental Materials.

Effortful Engagement

Figure 1 presents the unstandardized path estimates for the model testing the indirect effect of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth

Figure 2
Indirect Effect of Emotional Clarity on Aggression via Effortful Disengagement Responses to Victimization



Note. Not shown are within-wave covariances or the predictive path for age.
$^{\dagger}p < .10$. $^{**}p < .01$. $^{***}p < .001$.

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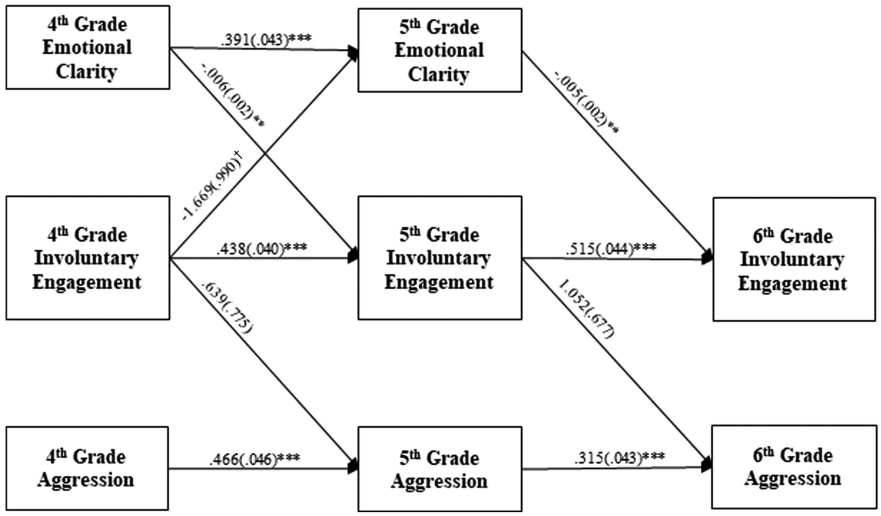
Figure 3

Indirect Effect of Emotional Clarity on Aggression via Involuntary Engagement Responses to Victimization

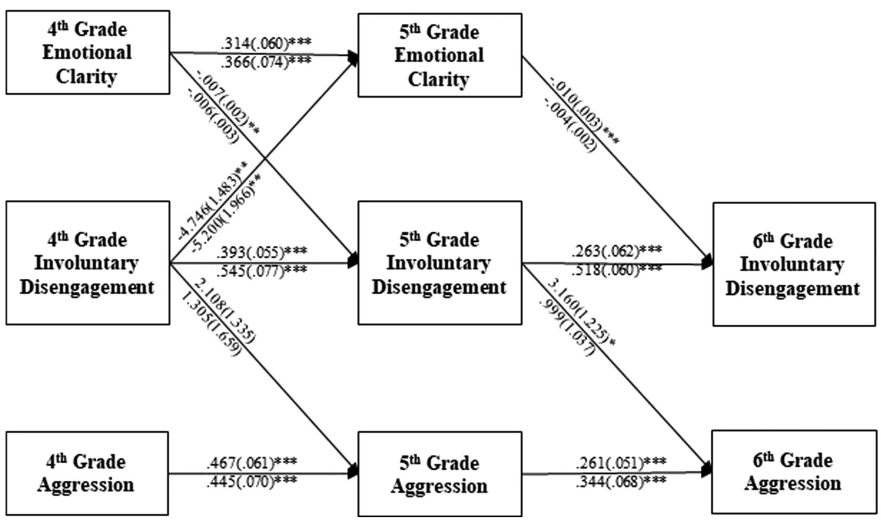


Note. Not shown are within-wave covariances or the predictive path for age.
† $p < .10$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

grade aggression via fifth grade effortful engagement. As hypothesized, fourth and fifth grade emotional clarity predicted higher fifth and sixth grade effortful engagement, respectively. Also, as hypothesized, fourth and fifth grade effortful engagement predicted lower fifth and sixth grade aggression, respectively. Additionally, there was a significant indirect effect of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth grade aggression via fifth grade effortful engagement ($B = -.01$, $SE = .01$, 95% CI [−.023, −.001]). With regard to reverse direct effects, as hypothesized, fourth grade effortful engagement predicted higher fifth grade emotional clarity.

Figure 4

Indirect Effect of Emotional Clarity on Aggression via Involuntary Disengagement Responses to Victimization



Note. Unstandardized coefficients for boys are on the top of the path, and unstandardized coefficients for girls are on the bottom of the path. Not shown are within-wave covariances or the predictive path for age.
* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

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Effortful Disengagement

Figure 2 presents the unstandardized path estimates for the model testing the indirect effect of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth grade aggression via fifth grade effortful disengagement. As hypothesized, fifth grade emotional clarity predicted lower sixth grade effortful disengagement. Additionally, fourth grade effortful disengagement predicted marginally higher fifth grade aggression. There were no other significant direct or indirect effects in this model.

Involuntary Engagement

Figure 3 presents the unstandardized path estimates for the model testing the indirect effect of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth grade aggression via fifth grade involuntary engagement. As hypothesized, fourth and fifth grade emotional clarity predicted lower fifth and sixth grade involuntary engagement, respectively. With regard to reverse direct effects, fourth grade involuntary engagement predicted marginally lower fifth grade emotional clarity. There were no other significant direct or indirect effects in this model.

Involuntary Disengagement

Figure 4 presents the unstandardized path estimates for the model testing the indirect effect of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth grade aggression via fifth grade involuntary disengagement. For boys but not girls, as hypothesized, fourth and fifth grade emotional clarity significantly predicted lower fifth and sixth grade involuntary disengagement, respectively. Additionally, for boys but not girls, as hypothesized, fifth grade involuntary disengagement predicted higher sixth grade aggression. The indirect effect of fourth grade emotional clarity on sixth grade aggression via fifth grade involuntary disengagement was significant for boys ($B = -.03$, $SE = .01$, 95% CI [−.037, −.006]), but not for girls ($B = -.01$, $SE = .01$, 95% CI [−.026, .005]). When examining reverse direct effects, for both boys and girls, as hypothesized, fourth grade involuntary disengagement predicted lower fifth grade emotional clarity.

Discussion

Theories of affective social competence propose that the experience of emotions can have downstream effects on social interactions and behavior (Camras & Halberstadt, 2017; Halberstadt et al., 2001). This research tested the proposition that compromised emotional clarity would interfere with youths' ability to enact adaptive responses (e.g., problem solving, emotion regulation, cognitive restructuring) and would trigger more maladaptive responses (e.g., rumination, emotional/physiological arousal, inaction) when faced with peer victimization (Burt & Donnellan, 2008; Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014; Mathews et al., 2014; Moustafa et al., 2017), which would increase their propensity for engaging in aggressive behaviors across the middle school transition (Crick, 1996). Consistent with this proposition, findings revealed that higher emotional clarity predicted more effortful engagement and less involuntary engagement (across sex) and involuntary disengagement (for boys) over time. In turn, effortful engagement predicted fewer subsequent aggressive behaviors (across sex), whereas involuntary disengagement responses to peer victimization predicted more subsequent aggressive behavior (for boys). Thus, there were significant indirect effects from emotional clarity to aggressive behavior via effortful engagement (across sex) and involuntary disengagement (for boys).

In the present analyses, sex differences only emerged in the model examining the indirect effect of emotional clarity on aggression via involuntary disengagement. As noted, for boys, more fourth grade emotional clarity indirectly predicted lower sixth grade aggression via lower fifth grade involuntary disengagement. For girls, neither the path from emotional clarity to involuntary disengagement nor from involuntary disengagement to aggression was significant. This pattern may, in part, be explained by sex differences in the consequences of stress and maladaptive responses to victimization. Researchers have argued that, when faced with stressors, males are more likely to engage in externalizing behaviors, whereas females are more likely to experience internalizing symptoms (Geary & Flinn, 2002; Hill & Durante, 2011; Preston et al., 2007). Therefore, the present study may have better captured risk in boys than in girls as a response to involuntary disengagement.

This study also revealed that youth who engage in more conscious, effortful engagement responses to victimization—such as regulating their emotions to reduce negative affective states, seeking out social support, or attempting to problem solve—have higher emotional clarity the following year. In contrast, youth who show more involuntary responses to victimization, such as involuntary action or emotional numbing, have lower emotional clarity the following year. These findings provide novel evidence that the way youth respond to stressors can impact emotional development, particularly the extent to which they are able to identify and understand their emotions. These findings may reflect the fact that youth who expend more conscious effort toward dealing with stressors are more likely to actively and constructively explore their emotions and, thus, become more in tune with their emotional states. In contrast, responding to stressors in a way that requires little cognitive effort (e.g., emotional numbing, escape) or reflects passive engagement in a cycle of repetitive and unproductive fixation on negative emotions (e.g., rumination, intrusive thoughts) may lead to missed opportunities to gain practice with identifying and understanding emotions. Therefore, consistently engaging in more involuntary responses to victimization—regardless of whether they are oriented toward or away from stressors—may compromise the development of emotional clarity.

Notably, although there were significant indirect effects from emotional clarity to aggressive behavior via effortful engagement (for both boys and girls) and via involuntary disengagement (for boys only), there were no significant indirect effects via effortful disengagement or involuntary engagement. Effortful disengagement encompasses conscious and/or controlled behaviors such as denial, wishful thinking, or purposely avoiding stressors. It is possible that youth who are low in emotional clarity may not have the capability to engage in conscious, effortful responses to stress when faced with peer victimization. Instead, they may be more likely to react in a more automatic, uncontrolled manner. Although youth with lower emotional clarity were more likely to show involuntary engagement responses to victimization, these responses did not predict subsequent aggression. It may be that involuntary engagement responses, such as rumination or emotional/physiological arousal, predispose youth to internalizing symptoms, such as anxiety and depression (Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014), rather than aggression.

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Implications, Limitations, Constraints on Generality, and Future Directions

The present study extends theories of affective social competence (Camras & Halberstadt, 2017; Halberstadt et al., 2001) and adds a valuable contribution to the empirical database examining the consequences of compromised emotional clarity by providing evidence of the resounding effects that lower emotional clarity can have on youth behavioral development. A few studies have shown that compromised emotional clarity can place youth at risk for internalizing symptoms (Flynn & Rudolph, 2010, 2014; Hamilton et al., 2016). However, the present study contributes to a growing literature indicating that deficits in emotional clarity also may increase youth risk of externalizing behaviors, such as aggression (Rudolph et al., 2020), which can have major ramifications for youth social development. It is important for future research to elucidate pathways and treatments that ultimately reduce behaviors such as aggression because past research has shown that aggressive youth are more likely to have poor relationships with peers (Farmer & Bierman, 2002; Yamasaki & Nishida, 2009), struggle academically (Chen et al., 2010; Farmer & Bierman, 2002), develop internalizing symptoms (Fite et al., 2019), and, in later years, are at greater likelihood of engaging in delinquency or criminal behavior (Vitaro & Brendgen, 2012).

Despite the strengths of the present study, including a three-wave longitudinal design with relatively low attrition, a multi-informant assessment approach, a large sample, and the conservative analytic approach in which we included autoregressive paths to adjust for earlier levels of the variables, there are also limitations that must be mentioned. First, the study relied on youth reports of emotional clarity and responses to victimization. Although these measures have well-established reliability and validity, self-reports may not reflect a comprehensive depiction of real-life emotional experiences and behaviors and are potentially susceptible to desirability effects. Behavioral observations or semistructured interviews may provide additional insight into emotional clarity and responses to victimization. Additionally, even though reports of responses to victimization and aggressive behavior were collected across all three waves, reports of emotional clarity were only collected for the first two waves. Consequently, we were not able to assess whether there was a reverse indirect effect of youth aggression on emotional clarity via responses to victimization.

Furthermore, the present study may have constraints on the generality of the findings due to the characteristics of the sample. To promote diversity in our sample, we recruited from seven different schools with a range of racial, economic, and cultural diversity. Although the majority (66.67%) of our participants were White, our sample did include multiple racial groups, and the diversity of the participants was similar to that of the general population in the United States at the time of data collection (USA Facts, 2024). However, the findings may not be generalizable to youth living in other countries or cultures—therefore, more cross-cultural research is needed to understand the paths leading from emotional clarity to aggressive behaviors. Additionally, at the time of data collection, we did not ask questions regarding gender identity. Future research is needed to understand how these pathways may differ for youth who identify as nonbinary, transgender, or otherwise gender nonconforming.

Notwithstanding these limitations, the present study provides the foundation for critical future research avenues. First, just as being the target of peer victimization may be a salient stressor that leads to maladaptive psychological and behavioral responses to stress, it also may lead to maladaptive physiological responses to victimization. When faced with stressors, youth show changes in the overall production of various hormones such as cortisol, salivary alpha-amylase, and dehydroepiandrosterone (Flinn et al., 2011; Wood et al., 2021). Furthermore, whereas acute increases in hormones in response to stress are adapted to promote short-term survival when placed in a stressful environment (Dhabhar, 2014; McEwen, 2004), prolonged elevation of these hormones can lead to a series of negative mental and physical health outcomes (McEwen, 2017; Wosu et al., 2013). It would therefore be fruitful to understand whether higher levels of emotional clarity may protect against heightened physiological responses to victimization to foster healthy developmental outcomes for youth who are the targets of peer victimization. Second, given the present results showing that emotional clarity may be one catalyst in promoting resilience during the transition to middle school, a time when many youth experience peer victimization, efforts should be aimed at developing early education programs that focus on teaching students ways to accurately identify their emotions and to best deal with peer stressors to reduce later rates of aggression as they enter into the next stage of development.

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Erratum to "The Need for a Unified Language Framework in Extrinsic Interpersonal Emotion Regulation Research" by Walker et al. (2025)

The article "The Need for a Unified Language Framework in Extrinsic Interpersonal Emotion Regulation Research," by Sarah A. Walker, Belén López-Pérez, Jens F. Beckmann, Hannah Kunst, and Shayne Polias (*Emotion*, 2025, Vol. 25, No. 4, pp. 922–928, https://doi.org/10.1037/emo0001463), had the incorrect open access license listed in the author note due to a processing error. The correct open access license for the article is CC BY 4.0; https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0. The online version of this article has been corrected.

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